The SSA, a bilateral instrument to protect the interests of Indian professionals as well as self-employed Indians working in foreign countries, was initiated by signing an SSA between India and Belgium on November 3, 2006. So far India has signed ***15 SSAs*** with Belgium, Germany, Switzerland, France, Luxembourg, Netherlands, Hungary, Denmark, Czech Republic, Republic of Korea, Norway, Finland, Canada, Sweden, and Japan. These SSAs facilitate mobility of professionals between two countries by exempting them from double payment of social security contributions and enables them to enjoy the benefits of exportability and totalisation.

## RURAL INFRASTRUCTURE

The Government of India has been according high priority over the years to building rural infrastructure with the objective of facilitating a higher degree of rural-urban integration and for achieving an even pattern of growth and opportunities for the poor and disadvantaged sections of society. Programmes for achieving this include the following:

***Bharat Nirman***

This programme, launched in 2005-06 for building infrastructure and basic amenities in rural areas, has six components, namely rural housing, irrigation potential, drinking water, rural roads, electrification, and rural telephony. A goal has been set to provide connectivity to all villages with a population of 1,000 (500 in hilly or tribal areas) with all-weather roads.

***Indira Aawas Yojana (IAY)***

The IAY is one of the six components of the Bharat Nirman programme. The unit assistance provided to rural BPL households for construction of a dwelling unit under the IAY has been revised with effect from April 1, 2010 from Rs. 35,000 to Rs. 45,000 for plain areas and from Rs. 38,500 to Rs. 48,500 for hilly/ difficult areas. In addition, construction of IAY houses have been included in the differential rate of interest (DRI) scheme for lending up to Rs. 20,000 per housing unit at an interest rate of 4 per cent. Sixty left wing extremism (LWE) affected districts have been made eligible for a higher rate of unit assistance of Rs. 48,500. Under this scheme a